the forefront of his mind, but that Nikita himself sometimes did not. As the British Ambassador to Moscow, Sir Frank Roberts, astutely observed, Khrushchev had a 'well-known proclivity for setting out on courses of action without correctly forecasting where they could lead him, coupled with his undoubted talent for making the best of the resulting situation.'[16] Scott Fitzgerald once observed that an artist is someone who can hold two opposing viewpoints and still remain fully functional. Khrushchev's artistry involved pursuing peaceful co-existence with the West while simultaneously confronting them with the threat of armed conflict and nuclear war.

Winter is coming

Khrushchev's priority in Vienna was Berlin, and he left unhappy about the lack of progress (though back in Moscow he portrayed his performance as a triumph). Moreover, he repeated his threat made in 1958, that if negotiations failed, he would unilaterally sign a peace treaty with the East Germans, this time by December 1961. The two leaders parted on 4 June 1961 with an ominous exchange. 'If the US wants war,' Khrushchev declared, 'that is its problem. It is not the USSR that threatens with war, it is the U.S.'[17] When Kennedy replied that it was Khrushchev who wanted to force change, Khrushchev declared: 'It is up to the US to decide whether there will be war or peace.' Kennedy responded: 'Then, Mr Chairman, it will be a cold winter.'[18]

Nevertheless, Kennedy signalled recognition of what he saw as the realities of a divided Europe. What happened in East Germany was a matter for the Soviets. Washington's interest lay in rights of access to West Berlin. Khrushchev, however, maintained his determination to sign a peace treaty with East Germany. His preferred option for Berlin was an 'open city', but if the West refused to sign the treaty, then Western rights of access would end.

Kennedy felt that the summit had been disastrous. Before he left Vienna, he told his friend James Reston of *The New York Times* that the encounter